along the way. It has already been noted, for example, how the Baku Congress was not as successful a meeting of Muslim and Bolshevik minds as Moscow would have liked it to be.[1] The signing of the trade agreement between Russia and Britain in 1921 had also proved a blow to the morale of Asian revolutionaries who had hitherto looked with expectation to the Soviet government for support in their anti-imperialist crusade. By agreeing to the clauses regarding dissemination of propaganda, it appeared to some that the Bolsheviks had sacrificed revolution in southern Asia for the sake of trade with Britain. As two Asian agitators lamented, the conclusion of the agreement had 'dealt a fatal blow at [sic] our work'.[2]

Furthermore, when it came to the treaties Soviet Russia had made with the various Asian nations, there was actually little significant gain to the Bolshevik cause. In fact, rather than being a sign of the Soviet government's increasing stature, the agreements of 1921 instead indicated 'the failure of Soviet propaganda to make any appreciable headway among the Muslims outside Soviet territory'.[3] The early Bolshevik hopes of being able to dispense with traditional diplomacy had proved wishful thinking, as year-on-year the world revolution failed to materialise. By 1921 the practicalities of international relations had forced the Soviet government to pay more attention to the matter of ambassadors, formal treaties and trade agreements; in the words of one writer, 'diplomacy was foisted upon a revolutionary regime'.[4] So began Bolshevik 'dual foreign policy' – the conducting of formal diplomatic relations with a country while using the Comintern to incite revolution among the people of that same nation.

However, while the Bolsheviks may have been more organised in their foreign affairs after 1921, they still faced two fundamental difficulties when it came to this dual policy in Asia: first was the incompatability of Communism and Islam. The second was the difficulty in getting Asian governments to play ball. Asian rulers appeared much more fair-weather in their diplomatic commitments. As the previous chapter has shown, the Bolshevik regime had quickly realised that having the Persian government sign an agreement and having the Medjliss ratify it were two different things. Even though they may have created treaties with Russia, Tehran, Kabul and Ankara had carefully 'avoided committing themselves to the principles of the Soviet social order'. They felt no qualms about breaching